

Bodhidharma and the Problem of Transmission

1. Two different questions

A traditional Chan genealogy places Bodhidharma between an Indian line of patriarchs and Chinese successors. Two questions must be separated. Historical question: what can be established about a sixth-century monk or group of traditions later called Bodhidharma? Genealogical question: what did it mean for later communities to organize authority as an unbroken transmission from Buddha to patriarch to patriarch? Evidence for one is not automatically evidence for the other.

2. Early evidence

The earliest materials associated with Bodhidharma are sparse and heterogeneous. The Two Entrances and Four Practices tradition presents a disciplined path of principle and practices, not yet the fully developed image of a fierce, wordless patriarch familiar from later Chan literature. Later biographies add details, miracles, dialogues, and succession claims. The direction of evidence matters: a later story can be excellent evidence for the concerns of the community that preserved it even when it is weak evidence for a sixth-century event.

3. Transmission as a claim

Consider: (1) religious authority requires a warranted relation to awakening; (2) a lineage represents such warrant as personal transmission; (3) a community publishes or recites the lineage; therefore (4) the genealogy does more than report ancestry - it distributes authority. The conclusion does not entail that every name was invented. It says that genealogies are institutional acts as well as historical propositions.

4. The 'separate transmission' formula

Later Zen repeatedly describes a transmission 'outside the teachings' or 'not dependent on words and letters.' Read this as a thesis that must be specified. It could mean that awakening is not exhausted by propositional understanding; that scriptural learning is insufficient without practice; that a teacher's authorization is indispensable; or, more radically, that texts are dispensable. The historical record strongly cautions against sliding from the first claims to the last. Chan monasteries copied, quoted, catalogued, commented on, and ritualized texts on a massive scale.

5. A diagnostic case

Suppose a tenth-century text attributes a pithy exchange to Bodhidharma and an emperor. If the exchange first appears centuries after the meeting it depicts, three reactions are possible. (A) Reject it and move on. (B) Accept it because tradition preserves it. (C) ask what doctrinal and institutional problem the story solves, then distinguish that function from the narrower question of verbatim historicity. This course generally prefers (C).

6. Question

If a lineage story is historically constructed but becomes the framework through which generations train, ordain, transmit, and interpret awakening, in what sense is it 'false'? Answering requires at least two standards of truth: correspondence to past events and effectiveness within a normative tradition. Keep them distinct before judging either.

A transmission argument

- 1 A lineage can authorize teachers only if the relation it records is treated as normatively significant.
- 2 Later Chan texts treat patriarchal succession as a privileged relation linking present teachers to earlier awakened figures.
- 3 The surviving evidence for the earliest links is much later and more literary than the evidence for many later institutional successions.
- 4 Therefore the lineage should not be used as a simple chronological list whose evidential status is uniform from Buddha to Song China.
- 5 It is better analyzed as a historical claim and as a technology of authorization, with separate evidence required for each role.

Defending the distinction

The conclusion is intentionally modest. It does not show that Bodhidharma never existed, that teachers never transmitted practices face to face, or that genealogies are uniquely deceptive. It says that a document can do something in the present while making a claim about the past. A charter can create an institution even if the story it tells about origins is selective. Chan genealogies similarly organize descent, succession, orthodoxy, and exclusion. John McRae's historical work is especially useful here because it treats lineage narratives as data about the communities that produced them rather than either literal transcripts or worthless legends.

Objection: function does not settle truth

Correct. Showing that a genealogy legitimates authority does not prove that a particular link is false. A functional explanation and a correspondence claim can both be true. The methodological rule is therefore not 'late means false.' It is: the later the source and the more developed its literary function, the less automatically it can be used as direct evidence for an earlier event. Corroboration, independent witnesses, earlier textual strata, and consistency with what is otherwise known all change the evidential weight.

The Bodhidharma dossier

The earliest Bodhidharma materials do not yet present the full classical package of nine years facing a wall, a dramatic imperial audience, Huike cutting off his arm, and a four-line verse defining Zen. Those motifs accumulate across different textual moments. Jeffrey Broughton's study of the material associated with the Two Entrances and Four Practices is therefore a useful control: it gives a picture of ascetic and Mahayana practice vocabulary that is recognizably Buddhist but not yet the polished icon of later encounter literature. The contrast lets us watch a founder being made without needing to reduce the process to fraud.

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ZEN.00 Zen: Texts, Practices, Institutions

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